FIELD NOTE

# What If Your Facts Are Wrong?

*On certainty, translation, and the things we stop checking.*

Every organization, and every person, runs on a handful of things they know to be true. The most dangerous of them is the one that has gone unchecked.

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# What If Your Facts Are Wrong?

A friend of mine believes the Dutch are rude. He is not casual about this belief. He has evidence: the clipped emails, the waiter who told him flatly that no, the kitchen would not be doing that, the colleague who heard his idea and said “that won’t work” before he’d finished the sentence. He has, over several years of living in Amsterdam, assembled a case file, and the case file is not eccentric — it is more or less the received opinion of an entire continent. Ask anyone who has spent time here. The Dutch, the story goes, will tell you exactly what they think of your haircut.

I offered him a different read one evening, mostly to see what he’d do with it. What if the rudeness he keeps encountering isn’t in the Dutch. What if it’s in the crossing.

Here is the thing that got him. The Dutch person telling him “that’s not possible” is speaking English — good English, fluent English, no accent to speak of, no groping for the word. And because the sentence arrives so clean, he assumes he’s receiving it the way he’d receive it from a native speaker of his own language: with everything a native signal carries. The softening. The “I’m not sure we can do that, but let me check.” The padding most of us bury our tone inside so nobody has to feel the edge of a no.

That padding was never in the sentence. The words are English. The wiring underneath is Dutch, and Dutch says the true thing plainly and trusts you to handle it. So what reaches him is a flawless English sentence with the cushion stripped out, and he has no way of knowing the cushion was ever supposed to be there. He doesn’t hear a direct answer from someone who respects him enough not to dress it up. He hears cold. He files it under rude.

I watched him do the math in real time, one encounter refiling itself after another. And I want to be careful here, because it’s the part he wanted resolved, and I don’t think it can be. Some people are, in fact, rude — that’s real, and it doesn’t stop at any border. Somewhere in his case file is probably a waiter who really was just having a bad night. The trouble is that from the outside, genuine indifference and unpadded honesty produce the same four words, in the same flat tone, and nothing in the sentence tells you which one you’re getting. My friend’s mistake wasn’t concluding that some interaction was hostile. It was believing he could tell.

*Certainty isn’t evidence that a belief is true. Usually it’s only a measure of how long the belief has gone unquestioned.*

That belief — that a small amount of evidence, repeated enough times, has earned the right to become a fact you no longer check — is not a Dutch story at all. It is the story of nearly every costly decision I have watched an organization make, and the shape is always the same. Somebody learns something true. The thing stays true for a while. Then, without anyone noticing the moment it happened, the world changes underneath the fact, and the fact does not update, because updating would require someone to admit they'd been checking something they'd long since stopped thinking of as checkable.

In the autumn of 2020, an analyst asked the leadership of an exercise-bike company how they planned to manage the risk of overbuilding once the world reopened and the pandemic surge in demand normalized. The answer, on the record, was that they did not expect it to normalize. On the strength of that conviction the company acquired a manufacturer, broke ground on a domestic factory, and staffed up for years of continued growth. The demand had been real. The reading of it was the error, and what makes the case worth dwelling on is the control group sitting right beside it: other companies, watching the identical surge in their own categories, read it correctly as a spike and scaled cautiously. Same evidence, arriving at the same moment, sorted into two different facts — because one company needed its version to be true and the other didn't.

A few years later, a studio's superhero film opened far below expectation, and within hours two competing explanations had taken up residence in the discourse. One camp said the film failed because of who was in it. The other said it failed because it had gotten political. Each side reached for its explanation with the particular speed of people confirming something they already believed, and each treated the confirmation as the end of the inquiry rather than the beginning of one. The measured audience data, when anyone eventually looked, told a quieter and less satisfying story: the specific audience the film needed didn't show up, the tone of it drove off a share of who did, and the word of mouth was poor from the first weekend on. None of this was hidden. It just required going back to look, and a story that already feels finished is a hard thing to reopen.

Southwest Airlines spent fifty years understanding its own customers' loyalty as something like affection — warmth, humor, the sense of a company that was on your side. Under pressure to lift revenue, it began charging for checked bags and moved to assigned seating, on the reasoning that people who loved the brand would forgive changes to the mechanics, because the relationship was never really about the bags. A competitor's chief executive eventually said the part Southwest hadn't: that a meaningful share of those loyal customers had been loyal to the free bags specifically, and were now, in his word, available. Southwest hadn't been failing when it made that decision. It had been profitable and admired and wrong about why — which is the version of this mistake that should trouble a healthy organization most, because nothing about looking healthy protects you from having stopped checking.

What connects the bike company and the studio and the airline to a waiter in Amsterdam is not the subject matter. It's the mechanism. A mind does not store the world; it stores a workable version of it and fills the gaps with what it has learned to expect, because a mind that reverified everything would never make it out of the driveway. So we carry yesterday's true thing forward as today's, and for a while that costs nothing, because for a while it's still true. The cost arrives later, subtly enough that nobody can point to the day it started, and by the time it's visible it usually shows up as a number: a demand curve that breaks, a loyalty that walks to a competitor, a friend who has spent three years being unfairly certain about an entire country.

None of the people in these stories were careless. That's the detail worth sitting with longest. The bike company's executives weren't fools, and neither is my friend. Each of them did the ordinary, necessary human thing of taking what had been true and treating it as though it still were, because the alternative — checking everything, always, against a world that won't hold still — isn't a discipline anyone could actually live inside. The failure isn't in trusting a fact. It's in forgetting that trust has an expiration date it doesn't announce.

I don't know, in the end, whether the waiter who turned my friend down was having a bad night or simply telling him the truth without dressing it up, and I've come to think that not knowing is the honest position, not a failure to reach one. He still doesn't know either. What changed, over the course of that one dinner, wasn't the answer. It was the recognition that he'd never actually had one — only a feeling fluent enough, repeated often enough, to pass for a fact. He ordered another beer, ran back through a few more entries in his case file, and got a little more subdued for a while, the way people do when a thing they'd stopped questioning has just been handed back to them as a question.